

The Winter Soldier, from the cover to *Captain America (2005) #9* by Steve Epting with colors by Frank D'Armata.

innovative design and thrilling spy stories to the medium at a time when Steve Rogers had been brought back into the active world of Marvel heroes. The modern version of Captain America had only been around for five years when Brubaker first became aware of the character.

"I first heard of Captain America and Bucky when I was three years old and my family lived on the Navy base in Gitmo. They showed those Marvel cartoons from the late '60s then on the Navy base's TV channel. The first one I ever saw was the origin of Captain America where Bucky stumbles into the tent and finds out his friend is Captain America and decides to be his partner, but I always knew the story of how Bucky got blown up by Baron Zemo at the end of the war," Brubaker explains.

When Brubaker's family moved to San Diego five years later, he went to his first comic-book convention to search for the back issue in which teen-sidekick James "Bucky" Barnes had been blown up.

There was no such back issue. Marvel Editor in Chief Stan Lee had decided to bring back Captain America in 1964 as a modern Rip Van Winkle, but he'd added a timeless level of tragedy to Steve Rogers' story. Joe Simon and Jack Kirby's 1941 Captain America would not work in the '60s as a patriot fighting Nazis. But he worked brilliantly as a man out of time, his quest for freedom and justice contrasting with the complex political atmosphere of the era.

Bucky had been left in the past, retroactively written out of the story—his dying breath the last thing Captain America saw before being frozen in ice. Twenty-three years earlier, Lee's first Marvel work had been a two-page prose